Funny old game.

As part of what was literally an open-door policy, I had resolved to invite former England greats into the dressing room to share our ambitions and understand our strategies. Beefy Botham had been with us that week; his role included the ceremonial awarding of the football trophy. The early morning kickabout had been banned by the ECB until Farby announced, in that languid way of his, 'I don't care. Let's play.'

The acid test of such new-found inclusivity and positivity was, of course, defeat. We were smashed in the next Test, at Lord's. Steve Smith got a double hundred and put on 284 for the second wicket with Chris Rogers, who made 173. I had my brain fade against Mitch Marsh at 96 in the first innings before we were bowled out for 103 in thirty-seven overs in the second, to lose by 405 runs.

Here we go again. Mitchell Johnson was hailed as a heavy-metal hero. Some sages missed the point by suggesting we were handicapped by playing on poor county pitches, but Mitchell took the pitch out of the equation: we don't often face bowling of that pace and quality in England. Our shot selection was poor. It was a pick-and-mix assortment of excuses and familiar complaints. 'The sun will come up in the morning,' Bayliss assured us. 'It's OK. We've just lost a game of cricket. We'll regroup.'

With that, he ushered us into two of the best weeks of our lives.

I hardly slept over that fortnight, a maximum of three hours each night. The difference was that my insomnia was due to excitement at the possibilities of a rapidly developing team, rather than dread of the consequences of individual or collective failure. The new mood was natural, rather than a shallow piece of public relations. Even the nerves had a different connotation. Everything felt right.

Jimmy Anderson, my best mate, blew the Edgbaston Test wide open by taking 6–47 in 14.4 overs before limping off with a side strain halfway through his ninth over in the second innings. Steve Finn, branded as 'unselectable' by Ashley Giles on the 2013–14 tour of Australia, had his moment of redemption, compensating by taking another six wickets.

We were way ahead of the game and needed only to chase down 121. I got out cheaply and when Adam Lyth was dismissed in the afternoon session on the third day, we were 51–2, and playing at run-a-ball pace. Great for the fans, but terrible for my blood pressure. I even asked Reg, our